Aging and Longevity: Active Aging Begins at Birth!

The buzz is all about active ageing and longevity these days. If our goal is to live as long as possible while being as healthy and functional as possible, then perhaps we need to return to what we learn from our developmental growth from birth through each stage of development.

We observe babies as they rapidly age socially, physically and cognitively. As caretakers, we try to provide good nutrition, promote exercise, and encourage social relationships. At each stage of development, the same fundamental elements are essential but… life happens, and we must adapt and adjust. It requires facing each stage by holding an authentic mirror to who we are, who we are becoming, and who we wish to be.

The Difference Between Active Ageing and Longevity

Active ageing focuses on the **quality of life** as people age. It emphasises engaging in health-promoting activities, maintaining physical and mental well-being, and staying socially and economically active. As we enter our older years, active ageing encourages us to live healthier, more engaged lives, promoting not just longer life, but also better health, independence, and productivity throughout the ageing process.

Longevity refers to the length of life or the **lifespan** of an individual. It is concerned primarily with how long we live, often measured in terms of average life expectancy. Longevity is influenced by genetic, environmental, and lifestyle factors, but it does not necessarily imply the quality of life. All sorts of popular treatments, pills, and drugs may try to alter what appears externally, but in order to reach our goal, we must align how we look with awareness of our inner world: how we feel in our minds, bodies and hearts.

> Balancing toward our centre energises our life force—it continuously refuels us to meet the challenges and wonderment of our daily experiences.

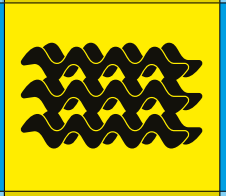
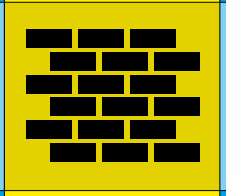
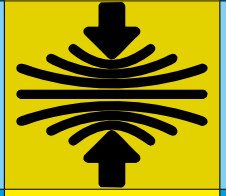
Longevity: Habits to Develop Your Personal Lifeforce

The sooner we develop awareness and foster practices and routines to create habits of body (balanced movement), mind (cognitive awareness), and heart (emotional awareness), the greater the impact will be on our quality of life.

Body Awareness

The head, the heart, and the body work together in harmony

TAP STRENGTH

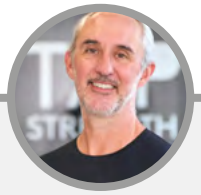
		Habits of Movement	Habits of Mind
PERSIST		**Persist:** Stick with it through temporary pain to achieve long term gain	**Persisting:** Activate your mind and get ready to stick with the routines.
BALANCE		**Balance:** Create connections in mind and body	**Managing Impulsivity:** Practice staying grounded with patience and allow the productive tension of the challenge to drive us forward and allow us to find our balance
POWER		**Power:** Control force and generate energy efficiently	**Taking a Responsible Risk:** React in a given challenging environment by controlling and releasing force
FLOW		**Flow:** Coordinate whole body movements effortlessly	**Responding with Wonderment and Awe:** Celebrate successes. Try to flow like a river--no forcing or holding back--rediscover what it is to feel like a child.
STABILITY		**Stability:** Build a strong foundation from your core	**Striving for Accuracy:** Pay attention to how to develop a strong and stable spine so that there is a solid foundation from which you can build and grow.
ELASTICITY		**Elasticity:** Grow stronger connective tissues to improve range of motion	**Thinking flexibly:** Gain more resilience when you are pushed to your limit to withstand stress
RECOVER		**Recover:** Bounce back from physical stress to restore your body in the moment	**Questioning and Posing Problems:** Time to have a conversation with your body asking: “how do I feel now?’ What do I need to remember?
GROW		**Grow:** Continue growing your body from the inside out and from the ground to the head and the head to the ground.	**Remaining Open to Continuous learning:** Discover the benefit of a new connection and commit to a pathway for its growth

As we build techniques and behaviours for developing fitness, it is not about how well we can follow a set of routines someone else prescribes. Rather, it is about how well we gather data from all of our senses and know what actions to take to maintain our best balance toward our centre. Balancing toward our centre energises our life force—it continuously refuels us to meet the challenges and wonderment of our daily experiences.

Tip: There are many examples of how you can use your exercises to cultivate your life force energy. For example, many people perform the squat. Next time, try this:

- As you lower into the squat, inhale to absorb force
- As you rise out of the squat, exhale to release force
- Repeat 8–10 times

The synergy of using your breath through the stress of repetition prepares you to withstand possible repetitive strain, for example, when sitting in front of a computer screen for many hours of work. This absorbing and releasing of force cultivates and powers your life force energy.



EJ Zebro

EJ Zebro brings over 25 years of expertise in teaching the art of functional movement. His journey began at The University of Delaware, where he pursued a degree in Exercise Science while playing D1 soccer. As a certified Chiropractic Sports Physician (CCSP), EJ further honed his abilities working as a strength and conditioning coach for over two decades. Through his hand-on approach to working with clients, EJ developed the proprietary TAP fascial manipulation methodology, the foundation for TAP's approach to increasing physical performance and fostering a deep sense of body awareness. This approach has proven to decrease the rate of injury while expediting recovery time. EJ is passionate about helping his clients TAP IN to their internal experience and TAP OUT to understand how their bodies move through time and space. His goal is to help individuals thrive through all stages of life and to help others heal themselves.

Dr. Bena Kallick

Dr. Bena Kallick is an author, speaker, and educational consultant who has co-authored many books on Habits of Mind with Arthur Costa. She most recently co-authored Students at the Center: Personalized Learning with Habits of Mind with Allison Zmuda. Costa and Kallick are the co-founders of the Institute for Habits of Mind.

She can be contacted by email at:
kallick.bena@gmail.com